

Exam Technique & The Reading Method ★

GL-style Poem Comprehension — copy every box below into your notes

✎ WHAT THIS SECTION OF THE EXAM ACTUALLY TESTS

GL-style poem comprehension papers do not just ask "what happened in the poem?" — they test six separate skills. Copy this list down and learn it, because every question you will ever see fits into one of these six boxes:

SKILL	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE IN A QUESTION
1. Retrieval	"What does the poem say happened to the boat?" — the answer is stated directly in the text.
2. Vocabulary-in-context	"What does the word 'drifted' suggest in this poem?" — you must use the surrounding lines, not just a dictionary definition.
3. Inference	"How does the poet feel about the sea?" — the answer is not written directly; you must work it out from clues.
4. Language & device effect	"Why has the poet used the metaphor 'the sea was a wolf'?" — you explain the effect of a technique.
5. Structure & form	"Why is the last line so short?" — you explain a structural choice (stanza length, rhyme, line breaks).
6. Overall meaning / theme	"What is the poem mainly about?" — you sum up the whole poem in one sentence.

Exam tip: before you even look at the questions, silently ask yourself "what is this poem actually about, and how does the poet feel?" Ninety percent of hard marks come back to this one idea.

✍ STRUCTURE 1 — THE R.E.A.D. METHOD (HOW TO READ THE POEM ITSELF)

STRUCTURE 1 OF 5

R.E.A.D.

1. **R — Read** the poem twice, all the way through, before looking at any question. First time: just enjoy it. Second time: read slower.
2. **E — Examine** the title. The title is often the biggest clue to the whole poem's meaning — write one word next to it describing what you expect the poem to be about.
3. **A — Annotate** as you go: underline any word that creates a strong feeling (happy, sad, scared, lonely, excited), circle any device you spot (simile, metaphor, personification), and put a "?" next to anything confusing.
4. **D — Decide** the poem's overall mood and theme in one sentence before you touch a single question. Write it in the margin. Every answer you give afterwards should agree with this sentence.

Copy this out three times below until you can say it from memory:

✍ STRUCTURE 2 — P.E.E.L. FOR EVERY WRITTEN ANSWER

STRUCTURE 2 OF 5

P.E.E.L.

1. **P — Point.** Answer the question directly in your first sentence. Do not describe the poem first — answer it.
2. **E — Evidence.** Quote the exact word or phrase from the poem in quotation marks.
3. **E — Explain.** Say what the word/phrase/device actually does — what picture, sound, or feeling it creates.
4. **L — Link.** Connect it back to the question and, if you can, to the poem's overall mood or theme.

Sentence starters to copy down and reuse: "This suggests..." / "This creates an impression of..." / "This implies that the poet feels..." / "This is effective because it makes the reader picture/hear/feel..."

STRUCTURE 3 OF 5

S.N.I.P.E.R. (for GL-style multiple choice questions)

1. **S** — **Skim** all the options before choosing — never pick the first one that "sounds right".
2. **N** — **Negate** any option that is factually wrong or contradicts the poem — cross it out immediately.
3. **I** — **Identify** "half-right" traps: options that use a real word from the poem but twist its meaning. These are the most common wrong answers in GL papers.
4. **P** — **Pick** the option that is closest to what the text actually says or clearly implies — not the most dramatic or interesting-sounding one.
5. **E** — **Evidence-check**: go back to the poem and find the line that supports your chosen answer.
6. **R** — **Re-read** the question one final time to confirm you've answered exactly what was asked (not a nearby, similar-sounding question).

✎ STRUCTURE 4 — THE 5-POINT INFERENCE CHECKLIST

STRUCTURE 4 OF 5

Before you answer any inference question, tick off these 5 points

1. Have I found the exact line(s) the answer comes from?
2. Am I using a clue, not just guessing from the general "feel" of the poem?
3. Have I avoided repeating the question word-for-word without adding new information?
4. Does my answer match the mood/theme sentence I wrote at the start (Structure 1, step D)?
5. Have I explained *why*, not just *what*?

STRUCTURE 5 OF 5

Step-by-step plan for the real exam

1. **Minute 0–2:** Read the poem twice (R.E.A.D. method). Do not rush this — a fast wrong read costs more time than a slow correct one.
2. **Minute 2–3:** Write your one-sentence "mood and theme" note in the margin.
3. **Minute 3–4:** Skim every question once so you know what's coming — this helps your brain notice clues on a re-read.
4. **Minute 4 onward:** Answer retrieval and vocabulary questions first (fast marks), then inference and device questions (slower, need more thought).
5. **Last 2 minutes:** Re-read your written answers — check every one starts with a direct answer (P.E.E.L. Point), and check multiple-choice answers against S.N.I.P.E.R. one more time.
6. **Never leave a blank.** An educated guess using a real clue from the poem is always worth more than nothing.

✎ KEY TERMS TO KNOW (COPY THESE DEFINITIONS DOWN)

TERM	DEFINITION
Stanza	A group of lines in a poem, like a paragraph (also sometimes called a "verse").
Rhyme scheme	The pattern of rhyming words at the end of each line, labelled with letters (e.g. ABAB, AABB).
Rhythm / meter	The regular beat or pattern of stressed and unstressed syllables in a line.
Enjambment	When a sentence runs on from one line to the next without punctuation, creating flow or urgency.
End-stopped line	A line that ends with punctuation (full stop, comma), creating a pause or sense of completeness.
Caesura	A deliberate pause in the middle of a line, often shown with punctuation, used to create dramatic effect.
Free verse	Poetry with no fixed rhyme scheme or meter.
Tone	The poet's or speaker's attitude towards the subject (e.g. mournful, joyful, angry, nostalgic).
Mood / atmosphere	The feeling created in the reader (e.g. tense, peaceful, eerie).
Persona / speaker	The "voice" telling the poem — not always the poet themselves.

Common mistake to avoid: never write "the poet uses a metaphor to describe the sea" and stop there. That is only the Point. You must add the Evidence (quote), the Explain (what picture it creates) and the Link (why it matters) — see Structure 2.

PRACTICE: APPLY R.E.A.D. RIGHT NOW

Before your next poem, write your R.E.A.D. steps here so it becomes automatic:

Title of poem: _____ What I expect it to be about: _____

One word for the mood after my first read: _____

My one-sentence theme note:

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